

Trapped Online

Forward:

The world as we have known it was beyond repair. War, universal events, and the general lack of care given to our planet had rendered Earth inhospitable, without any way to escape the charred wasteland. A temporary ceasefire was called, in efforts to save the human race from completely wiping ourselves out of existence, and a plan was created. A nuclear fallout shelter was created amongst the largest nations and populated with a seed bank of every possible organism known to man. It spanned billions of entries, with thousands of samples for each one, including plants, animals, insects, even humans. We created an infinite amount of energy with nuclear generators, located on the other side of the planet from the seed banks, that were completely self-sufficient, and with a less than one percent chance of failing over a million years. The next part took a bit of convincing for the general populace to accept. We were going to digitize the current human population. Each human would be scanned and put into a cryo-sleep to outlast our normal live-spans, until we could find a solution to our singular planetary problems. Meanwhile, their consciousness would be duplicated, and Uploaded into a digital media space that had originally been programmed as an online multiplayer video game, but would now serve as the new home of humanity. The original game had been named after the creator, Taikan Runson, and was called Runson's Refuge,. After the Upload though, it was renamed to served a more appropriate name based on the popular Steven Lisberger film and stories; Runson's Grid.

Prologue:

The upload colors and lights flashed by as Blake began his link process to the server. Even though he had done this hundreds of times, the feeling of rushing into a different world never got old. As the boot up noise sounded, he mentally ran through the checklist for today's matchup. This was the semi-finals round, no more joking around. Anyone at this stage deserved

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to be here, and that meant they were dangerous. He was expecting to see a straightforward line-up from the opponents, though it never hurt to make sure.

As the fantastical world of digital reality began to blink into existence around him, Blake immediately pulled up the tournament registry by swiping his hand in the familiar fashion, from chest to forehead next to his eye line, and navigating to the information packet on all the registered players for the tournament. He scrolled past his own team, The Templars, and found today's matchup, Scrumptious Scallywags. Of course, it had to be another pirate pun. Then again, they had already made it past five other rounds before, so they had to be doing something right. He looked quickly at registered players and found what he was looking for. Two musketeers, one powder monkey, and a captain. Obviously, they all had themed roles, but it was pretty standard, though the two long range combatants would possibly make things tricky.

As Blake closed the menu in thought, he took in the rest of his surroundings, finding himself in the same place he had left yesterday. The outside of the arena appeared to be fashioned as some desolate ruins, with a perfectly intact Colosseum in the center. Inside were grandstandings for viewers to witness any ongoing tournament matches that took place in the pit. Inside the pit was a blank battlespace, until the horn sounded marking a match to begin. At that time, a blanket of fog would rise upwards and create a magical battlefield, generated by a tournament official, but the plans were never released before matches, so as to not give any one team an advantage when planning out a strategy. It was also common for the viewers above to take bets on the outcome of matches, like sports betting, when it was still around. Not many entertainment sectors had survived the current state of the world outside of the game, but at least the sports-heads still had their hobbies.

Soon after he had completed his strategy plans, he began to get several notifications that the rest of his guild were teleporting to his location. He stood from his seated position upon one of the rocks nearby, and looked towards where he knew they would come in. Three pillars of blueish light seemed to rise over the horizon, dancing with rainbow streaks as they progressed, and began their downward arc towards him, each landing several yards away from him. He already knew their faces before they stepped out of their personal Bifrost

translocators, knowing instinctively at this point after spending so many days and nights with his teammates. Ev was the first to step out of her pillar of light, shrouded in her purple leather jerkin and a hand resting on her rapier at her side. She swept the dark hair out from her eyes as she looked side long at the others, waiting for them to step out as well. Felix, the warrior, stepped out next. His large shield was slung along his back, with his broadsword resting in its scabbard at his side. He flipped the visor from his helmet up, his usual grin plastered across his face. Holly came shortly behind, flying out from her beam already seated atop her flying broom, dark cloak billowing behind her. She did a miniature fly circle above the now fully assembled group before landing lightly next to them. She blew a bubble from her purple bubblegum and let it pop, continuing to chew it. How long she had been working on the current piece, it was hard to say.

“So Green, what’s the plan? The usual I’m guessing?” Ev was the first to speak, twirling her throwing knife between two fingers as she looked intently towards the awaiting Colosseum. Blake knew her calm and calculating demeanor well and saw it in full swing. Dozens of potential conflicts flew through her head as she planned out imaginary routes through an unknown cover layout, sneaking behind lines.

“It’ll be a little different this time actually. The Scallywags have got two listed musketeers, making your usual flanking routine a bit harder to pull off. However, it will be all the better should you get to it, so we’ll need some extra heavy distraction today. Holly, you up for some mischief?” Blake responded, sending the lineup information to his teammates. They each opened their own menus to glance at Blake’s gathered information.

Included were the other team’s special roles, but also a preparation guide, with mock-up battle lines drawn on a few standard arena layouts from previous arenas in the tournament. It wouldn’t be a perfect plan, since they had never seen the future layout, but it was a loose enough plan that whatever showed up wouldn’t completely derail their execution. Ev nodded along thoughtfully, the notes seeming to form in her own head as fast as Blake had come up with them earlier.

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“Shouldn’t be a problem. I made sure to bring my utility spell book today just in case. Had a feeling that we’d need it this late into the tourney,” Holly pulled a large leather-bound book from her satchel, riffling through the pages until she found something she seemed to like, bringing a smirk to her face, “Oh yeah, I’ve got just the right combination.”

“What about me today, Boss? You want the usual, or something different?” Felix hopped from one foot to the other in anticipation and also to keep himself warmed up. He was always in chase of the simplest option, choosing to charge headlong into any foray and ask questions later.

“Not quite Felix. We’re going to try something a little different,” Felix’s face began to drop slightly, which Blake quickly made to change, “Don’t worry though, it’ll just be a variation of your favorite. You’re still going to be at the forefront of the fight. However, your job today is to get their attention. And I mean ALL of it.” The start of a crestfallen face began to return to a ginormous grin.

“Sounds like a plan Boss! I’m itching to get started!” Felix banged a gauntlet on his plate armor, sending a ring through the air. At the same time, a bell chimed far off from the direction of the center of the ruins, almost as if it was echoing Felix’s call to arms. Blake turned once more to Ev, seeing her calculating face turn over the ideas in her head.

“You and I are responsible for the powder monkey and musketeers. Ready to bring the pain?”

Ev’s face pulled into a small smile, anticipating the upcoming challenges. “Silent as a shadow, deadly as the plague.”

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“Ladies and Gentlemen! Today is the first round of the semifinals to our annual Clan Clash Showdown!” An announcer’s voice rang from above the portcullis around the battlefield, providing ample sound to everyone in the arena. A roar of approval was heard clearly inside of the tunnel that The Templars found themselves in, each going through their pre-battle routines. Blake had just finished stringing his bow and was checking the fletching’s on each of his arrows,

Ev was checking her weapons could pull freely from her sheaths, Felix had buckled his shield onto his off-hand arm, and Holly was memorizing spell incantations while sitting cross legged against the wall. Each of them looked up from their respective tasks glancing at one another then out towards the field.

“In today’s first match we have the mighty Templars! Formed under Blake the Ranger, this dynamic bunch of traditional heroes have been a consistent top performing group since the start of this tournament. Will this be their year to take home the coveted yearly artifact? Or will the newcomers, The Scrumptious Scallywags, rob these fantasy heroes of their booty like all those before? We find out in but a few short minutes!” The Templars began to take their places, each lining up within the hallway. Felix lowered his visor, ready for battle as Holly hovered above his head on her broom, readying her shielding spells to support the team. Ev took her position on the left side of the opening, crouched low with a smoke device already held in hand. Blake took his position on the right, an arrow already knocked to the string as the announcer went over the rules, “Remember everyone, we aren’t savages here! There will be no killing in this tourney, only incapacitating. Any legendary artifacts are prohibited, but other magical items are allowed. The match will conclude when there is only one team left standing! Contestants! It’s Showtime!” The announcer hung on to the end of each sentence, dragging the crowd into a frenzy. The roar of the crowd was deafening as a bell chimed three times and the battlefield began to shimmer with fog from each direction, leaving behind large wooden structures and obstacles, reminiscent of the deck of a cargo ship that was overloaded. The gates crashed down into their holdings below as the battle commenced.

Ev immediately pulled the pin from her tool and launched it forward before the gates were even halfway down, expertly laying it into the middle sightline of the field, knowing that’s where the enemy musketeers would be looking. Holly’s prepared spell hit each of them in tandem, providing a translucent shield to hover around each of them. Felix gave a war cry to match a lion, drawing his sword and rushing into the smoke, banging his weapon against his shield. Ev had already slipped away to the left, hood drawn above her head, with the shadows bending around her to conceal her approach. Holly flew up and overhead, whisking her hands in multiple directions before a crackle of thunder began to sound.

Each of them had their roles, and the two in the middle were running interference and distraction. Ev was already on the move, spurring Blake into action. He drew his arrow halfback and launched it in the direction he knew the pirates would be coming from before sliding behind a large crate. He peaked his head around, hoping his cloak's magical properties would allow the light to bend around him and conceal his position. He noticed the two musketeers had already split to opposite sides of the deck, one standing at a position that looked to be an area that a normal ship's steering platform would be, while the other was climbing some rope rigging to the right, a flintlock held between his teeth. The captain was barking orders at his crew, scimitar drawn as he marched down the bow towards Felix's cries for attention. The powder monkey was nowhere to be found, but Blake knew that if left alone, the bombardier would begin to cause problems.

He quickly selected an arrow that held a lead weight as a tip instead of a war head and aimed for the climber. He made sure to position the shot a few degrees higher, accounting for the extra drop before releasing. He knew the shot was good before it was even halfway, already turning before he heard the shout of pain as the ball slammed into the pirates shooting arm. He fell a few feet before his legs got tangled into the roping, catching his descent, but rendering him immobile while he hung upside down. An explosion of gunpowder rang out as the first musket owner took a shot at Blake missing by a few feet over his head. Blake dove to his left behind a different structure, a lookout position, but opted to stay at ground level rather than climb into the nest. He peaked around the opposite side from where he came, scanning for the powder monkey.

Felix had engaged the captain at this stage, blades dancing in a mesmerizing pattern of hacks, blocks, slashes and parries. The knight caught just as many strikes on his shield as the captain deflected to the side or danced out of the way. They seemed nearly evenly matched, but Felix was gaining ground, pushing the pirate into a corner. From above, Holly produced a snowball and hurled it behind the captain, freezing the ground behind him. His boots, made for water-soaked lumber and not frozen conditions, slipped from underneath him, dropping his guard for just a fraction of a second. It was all Felix needed as he closed the distance and smashed his shield against the pirate's crown, knocking him to the floor with a single hearty

blow. His form crumbled as his knees gave way and the tangle of limbs fell to the floor. The crowd that had been cheering and applauding before went berserk before the demonstration of skill and efficiency, shouting their approval for the knight in shining armor.

The first musketeer lined up a shot and finally fired, the sound of the miniature explosion ringing out, quickly followed by a splintering of wood, then Holly's curses as the front of her broom was shattered, knocking the magical flight spell out and plummeting towards the ground. Felix instinctively dropped his broadsword while diving underneath the flailing witch, catching her small form just before she hit the ground. He quickly rolled to the side behind the large mast in the center of the arena, shielding them both from any ongoing fire whilst the witch mumbled about her broken broom now half its original length and still clutched in her hands.

Blake's gaze drifted to the left to see that Ev had upheld her specific mission, seeing a pair of flailing legs upended in a barrel of what could only be a large supply of gunpowder. The powder monkey's striped pantaloons kicked back and forth to no avail, obviously stuck fast. The last remaining member of the group seemed to realize his predicament at the same time, as he swung to his left to see any flankers. However, it was too late he realized, as the assailant was long gone and had gone a different route as a throwing knife sailed end-over-end through the air, striking hilt first into the man's cloth-covered temple. The crowd roared as he toppled over the railing he had taken a vantage behind, dropping to the deck below. Ev appeared a moment later where her target had been standing, a grin spreading across her now relaxed features as the announcer came on once again.

"Ladies and Gentlemen, it appears we have a winner! In a spectacular, near perfect execution, the Templars have advanced to the final round!" The crowd erupted, screaming in delight at the spectacle that had been provided before their very eyes. The winners gathered in the center of the ship, standing in a reverse circle, waving to the crowd around them. Blake's hood was tugged a bit as an arm from the roguish girl was laid across his shoulders.

"See, that wasn't too bad, now was it?" Ev joked her eyes dancing with amusement.

“Speak for yourself. My broom got blasted. It’s going to take me hours to re-enchant a new one for the finals next weekend,” Holly’s usual pessimistic tone drew their attention before she looked away. “Thanks for the catch though big guy. You saved me quite the bruise for the next few days.”

Felix smiled and offered a childish bow, “Why of course madam, it was my honor.” Holly shoved his shoulder before chuckling and turning to address the crowd. Blake and Ev shared a look of amusement at their friend’s bickering before turning once again to their respective sides. It was at that moment that Blake’s vision of the world began to alter as his peripheral vision began to be encircled by red and a warning signal sounded in his ears. The crowd lost their enthusiasm quickly as it appeared that everyone around them was also beginning to get alerts flashing in their viewports. Soon, a large red box in the center of Blake’s vision appeared with a large warning text saying the most bone chilling words he’d ever read; “Runson’s Refuge will be closing in five minutes. Please log off and seek your nearest health center tomorrow to begin the upload process to the databank.”

Blake looked around him as it seemed his companions also had received similar messages. A look of fear had spread across Holly’s face, as puzzlement and worry jumped to Felix and Ev respectively.

“Looks like the finals are going to have to wait. I’ll text you all on the other side. Stay safe.” Blake grasped the forearm of Felix and laid a hand on Holly’s shoulder. They both nodded before swiping up on their menu and exiting out of the game. He turned to Ev, who let her guard slip just a fraction, allowing the panic to seep in. Blake drew her into a hug before continuing. “It’s going to be ok. I’ll see you soon” She nodded before offering a weak smile that didn’t quite reach her eyes before they simultaneously opened the menu and pressed the log out button.